



UNIVERSITÉ DE FRIBOURG
UNIVERSITÄT FREIBURG

CoARA Action Plan of the University of Fribourg

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1. Background and Values

In 2022, the University of Fribourg (Unifr) became the first Swiss cantonal university to join the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA), which was founded that same year. By taking this early position, Unifr emphasised the need for a review of existing research evaluation practices as part of its mission. Since then, CoARA has built up a great deal of momentum: Many other Swiss universities have now signed the CoARA agreement (UNIL, UZH, UNIGE and others), and a number of important Swiss research organisations have become full members (Swiss National Science Foundation, swissuniversities, Swiss Academies of Arts and Sciences, ETHZ, EPFL and others) like the Unifr. By joining CoARA, the Unifr has agreed to allocate resources for the revision of its own research assessment practices and to present an action plan that sets out the internal processes for implementing the CoARA commitments.

The CoARA commitments address many of the issues raised in the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), such as the privileging of qualitative over quantitative evaluation, and the effort to avoid inappropriate use of journal impact factors (JIF) and university rankings. They also address cross-cutting issues such as the recognition of the diversity of contributions to and career paths in research. The central concern of CoARA is the willingness of member institutions to rethink and, where necessary, redesign their own research evaluation practices in order to take into account the overarching principles of academic freedom, integrity, diversity, and transparency.

The Unifr views CoARA positively, since it is structured as a democratically managed and participatory initiative. By taking part in CoARA, we can actively engage in the international shift in research evaluation culture that has been emerging for several years. Furthermore, the Unifr's core values resonate strongly with the commitments outlined by the CoARA. They emphasize the importance of fostering a responsible, inclusive, and innovative research environment. A reflection on how the university's commitments align with CoARA's principles follows here:

Quality

The University of Fribourg's focus on excellence in education, research, and working conditions is directly aligned with CoARA's call for responsible and quality-focused research assessment practices.

- **CoARA Alignment:** Valuing diverse research outputs, including teaching, collaboration, and interdisciplinary work, requires a view that extends beyond traditional metrics. The Unifr is committed to the promotion of high-quality education and research, and recognises that this requires innovative and continuously developing frameworks for assessment and quality control.

Responsibility

The university's emphasis on ethical principles, social justice, and inclusivity reflects CoARA's commitment to fairness and equity in research assessment.

- **CoARA Alignment:** Encouraging the presence of women in teaching and research and supporting young researchers aligns with CoARA's focus on creating equitable opportunities for all researchers.

Durability

The commitment to sustainable development mirrors CoARA's emphasis on the long-term impact of research and the need for systemic change in research assessment.

- **CoARA Alignment:** The Unifr is committed to creating a work environment where actions for sustainable development are supported. In terms of research assessment this translates into a commitment to work towards inclusive, and thus ultimately robust, solutions that respect the varying needs and missions of the different faculties and research communities.

Readiness to Engage in Dialogue

The University of Fribourg's openness to dialogue and collaboration at local, national, and international levels aligns with CoARA's emphasis on collective action to advance research assessment reforms.

- **CoARA Alignment:** The university's focus on multilingual and interdisciplinary education and research, on transparency, and community participation creates a foundation for inclusive and participatory research assessment practices.

2. Implementing the CoARA Commitments

The CoARA agreement addresses research assessment practices in a very broad sense. In order to develop coherent and viable CoARA measures, close cooperation between different actors within the university structure is thus essential. The Unifr rectorate took the decision to create a CoARA working group (CoARA WG) in order to oversee the implementation of the CoARA commitments. The WG includes representatives of all faculties, as well as staff of the Open Science Office, the Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Office (EDI), the Quality Assurance Office, a representative of the Unifr research commission, and a representative of the non-professorial research and teaching staff. The Research Promotion Service (SPR) coordinates the CoARA efforts at the Unifr and runs the working group.

The CoARA WG will accompany the implementation of CoARA until the end of 2027.

3. Three Settings and Four Focal Points for Action

The Unifr CoARA WG has identified three key settings in which the Unifr is involved in processes of research assessment. These are:

- 1) **Recruitment and career assessment:** Recruitment and promotion of researchers, commissions approving Ph.D. dissertations or habilitations
- 2) **Assessment of proposals:** internal research funding allocated by the research commission
- 3) **Quality control of research conditions** for departments and faculties: Faculty research commissions, quality assurance office

The Unifr is engaged in continuously improving its research assessment and initiatives pertaining to this goal are currently ongoing at all levels of its administration (departments, faculties, central administration). Overall, four specific focal points for action can be identified:

- 1) **Review of career promotion processes** (the latter term refers specifically to the processes that promote tenured professors from the basic to the superior category, and decisions about giving tenure to assistant professors)
- 2) **Review of internal processes of proposal assessment**
- 3) **Integrating Open Science and research assessment**
- 4) **Engaging actively in strategic discussions on the future of research assessment:** Facilitating and participating in exchanges locally, as well as on a national and international level, raising awareness of developments in research assessment as a service to Unifr researchers, and making sure their voices are heard.

The first three focal points map on to the CoARA commitments 1) *Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research*; 2) *Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators*; as well as 3) *Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index*, and 6) *Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes*. While the fourth also sets an accent on the CoARA supporting commitments 7) *Raise awareness of research assessment reform*, and 8) *Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition*.

The remaining CoARA commitments are also being addressed by ongoing work at Unifr. Commitment 5) *Commit resources to reforming research assessment* is ongoing through the implementation and continuous work of the CoARA WG as well as through the time the SPR office invests in the implementation of CoARA at Unifr. The Unifr's participation in the CoARA national chapter of Switzerland further serves to implement commitments 8) *Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition* and 9) *Communicate progress made*, and Unifr seeks to ground all of this work on the latest available research on research, as required by commitment 10).

4. Ongoing and Planned CoARA Initiatives

4.1 Implementing DORA/CoARA Commitments 2) and 3)

Ongoing: The Unifr has made significant efforts over the past several years to implement DORA into its research assessment processes. All job offers for professorial posts refer to Unifr's commitment to DORA. Since 2020 all hiring procedures for new academic staff have also been accompanied by a best practice checklist that seeks to ensure that quality is valued over quantity when assessing the publication profile of a candidate, as well as to remind committee members that the Journal Impact Factor (JIF) is not an appropriate indicator to evaluate individual researchers. Furthermore, the EDI service of the Unifr also provides a short [video](#) that gives pragmatic input on how to implement the principles of DORA, and explains how these intersect with diversity issues in recruitment processes. Finally, the format of the procedure for evaluating professors, which has been implemented in all faculties since 2023, is explicitly based on the diversity of their research areas, tasks and priorities, as well as on a qualitative approach.

Planned: The CoARA WG will seek the input of the faculties on whether the DORA reference in job offers should be changed to CoARA terminology, in order to avoid confusion in our external communication and to include the Unifr's commitment to diversity (CoARA commitment 1) alongside its ongoing interest in privileging quality of research output over quantity (DORA and CoARA commitments). The DORA best practices checklist could also be renamed to ensure coherence in research evaluation efforts at Unifr and should be extended to include CoARA commitment 4) *Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment* in order to remind recruitment committees that university rankings should not be used in the assessment of individual researchers. The CoARA WG will then prepare recommendations on both these issues and communicate them to the faculties and other stakeholders.

Milestone 1: The CoARA WG will prepare a proposal for how to integrate the DORA and CoARA efforts for the attention and eventual approval of the rectorate by early 2026.

4.2 Review of Career Promotion Processes

Ongoing: Three Unifr faculties have already begun reviewing their internal career promotion processes. In 2023 the Deanery of the Faculty of Humanities has already approved an extensive vade mecum detailing best practices for the entire process of hiring a new professor, ranging from the corresponding structural commission to the recruitment commission and the specific criteria to be employed in the latter. The Faculty of Law is also in the process of reflecting on its criteria for the approval of Ph.D. and habilitation theses, and envisages to review the criteria for the promotion of professors as a next task for the corresponding working group within the faculty. Furthermore, the Faculty of Management, Economics and Social Sciences and the Faculty of Science and Medicine have produced guidelines for the promotion of its professors that include a detailed discussion of the criteria to be employed.

Planned: The CoARA WG will support all Unifr faculties in the review of career promotion processes. It will do so by connecting the individuals and working groups engaged in these efforts at faculty level, so that they can profit from each other's experiences and outputs. Furthermore, it will create a sub working group with a particular focus on the question of the criteria and processes employed in the recruitment and promotion of researchers and

teaching staff.¹ This sub-working group will develop recommendations that faculties can draw on in promotion and recruitment processes. Preliminary discussions in the WG have shown that excellence in teaching is highly valued at Unifr and should likely play a more important role in these processes. Moreover, there is support for using the 'net-academic age' as a tool across all career processes.

Milestone 2: CoARA sub-working group develops recommendations for the recruitment and promotion of researchers and teaching staff for approval by the rectorate by the end of 2025.

Milestone 3: All Unifr faculties have reviewed their processes for the promotion of professors by 2027.

4.3 Review of Internal Processes of Proposal Assessment

Ongoing: The Unifr has three internal funds that allocate research funding competitively (Centenary Research Fund, Research Pool, Doc.Mobility). Funding decisions are taken by the commission for the promotion of research and by the Council Office of the Board of Trustees, respectively. A number of commission members have changed over the past months, and some aspects of the administration of the three funds are in the process of being streamlined for more efficiency. This moment of transition is ideal to review Unifr proposal assessment processes. The SPR, which is tasked with the administration of these funds, has begun an exchange to this effect with the president of the commission for the promotion of research.

Planned: The SPR will analyse the proposals submitted to the commission over the past two years, to find out which submission categories have proved to be the most popular and what their respective success rates are. These findings will provide the basis for the formulation of guidelines for how to assess proposals with a specific view to how criteria might change in each category. Once these guidelines are approved by the rector and the commission, they will be made publicly available on the website of the internal research funds. All measures will be underpinned by an effort to minimise the effects of unconscious biases in the assessment process and a support of the Unifr's commitment to diversity across all levels of research.

Milestone 4: Revision and approval of detailed guidelines for the assessment of proposals in the frame of the Unifr's internal research funds by first quarter of 2026.

4.4 Integrating Open Science and Research Assessment

Ongoing: In 2024 the Unifr has restructured the administration of its libraries through the creation of a central office responsible for the coordination of all documentation centres and Open Science. This office also comprises a new Open Science team that has been created to support researchers in the Open Science transition. Services offered include support (incl. funding) for Open Access publications, tailored support for rendering data accessible according to FAIR principles, as well as the Open Science short lectures, which allow researchers to stay up-to-date with developments in the field. In the same year, the Unifr has become part of a consortium of twelve Swiss higher education institutes dedicated to the study of how to valorise and assess Open Research Data (ORD) practices in a responsible manner. This project entitled "recORD" is partially funded by Swissuniversities. Moreover, the

¹ Focusing specifically on the processes that promote tenured professors from the basic to the superior category, and decisions about giving tenure to assistant professors.

Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF) is a consortium partner and will receive the final project report with a view to implementing its recommendations in the future. Throughout the year the Unifr has held a series of internal workshops on how to assess ORD practices in proposal assessment, in recruiting and career development processes, and in the assessment of research-performing institutions, respectively. The results from these internal workshops were then brought to the consortium workshops, where all members worked towards the formulation of a set of recommendations.

Planned: The Open Science team of the Unifr will continue to support Unifr researchers in their FAIR Science projects and offer further educational courses on the subject. The recORD project will continue in 2025, so that consortium members can fine tune their common recommendations and continue to exchange on how to implement those.

Milestone 5: Internal discussions on how to integrate ORD practices into research assessment. Achieved in 2024.

Milestone 6: Contribute to the preparation and dissemination of the recORD recommendations in 2025.

4.5 Shaping the Future of Research Assessment: Participation and Dissemination

Ongoing: The Unifr considers it vital to take into account the specific situations and needs of its researchers in the continuous development of research assessment practices. It also recognises that with international research landscapes shifting and changing rapidly, it is important that its researchers are familiar with recent national and international developments in the evaluation of research. The role of the administrative and academic staff implementing CoARA at Unifr is thus twofold: We foster exchange between our researchers and, on the basis of their input, take an active part in local, national, and international discussions on the future of research assessment. Secondly, we disseminate important findings concerning changing practices in research assessment to those working at Unifr. The Unifr is an active participant in the Swiss CoARA national chapter (co-led by the Swiss Academies and the SNSF) where it exchanges regularly with other Swiss HEIs that are CoARA members. As mentioned above, we are also taking part in the Swissuniversities “recORD” project that aims to better recognise ORD practices in research assessment. The creation of the Unifr CoARA WG further serves to facilitate an internal dialogue regarding research assessment and raising awareness of CoARA across all faculties.

Planned: Unifr staff will continue to actively participate in the Swiss CoARA national chapter and the recORD project, and disseminate important findings at our institution. We will also seek membership in a CoARA working group (either “Evaluating Social Sciences and Humanities (SSH) research globally” or “Reforming Academic Career Assessment”) and contribute to its work from the perspective of Unifr researchers and funnel any insights into the corresponding Unifr initiatives. The Unifr WG will continue to coordinate the university’s CoARA implementation initiatives until 2027. At that time the WG will also lead a review and reflection process to evaluate changes made in accordance with CoARA commitments.

Furthermore, Unifr will draw up a Code of Conduct and legally valid guidelines that regulate cooperation and collaboration within the university community, with CoARA-relevant focal points such as research integrity, diversity and inclusion.

Milestone 7: Raise awareness of CoARA activities in all faculties through presentations at faculty council meetings and create a practice of sharing materials and other resources relating to CoARA activities across Unifr stakeholders through a digital sharepoint and a contact person in the SPR office.

Milestone 8: Seek membership in CoARA working group.

Milestone 9: CoARA review process 2027.

Milestone 10: Set-up, approval and promotion of Code of Conduct and legally binding guidelines by the end of 2025.